

Jagmohan Dalmiya makes a triumphant comeback to Eden Gardens with a thumping victory in CAB elections. But why is his new innings making his adversaries so nervous?

■ By Elora Sen

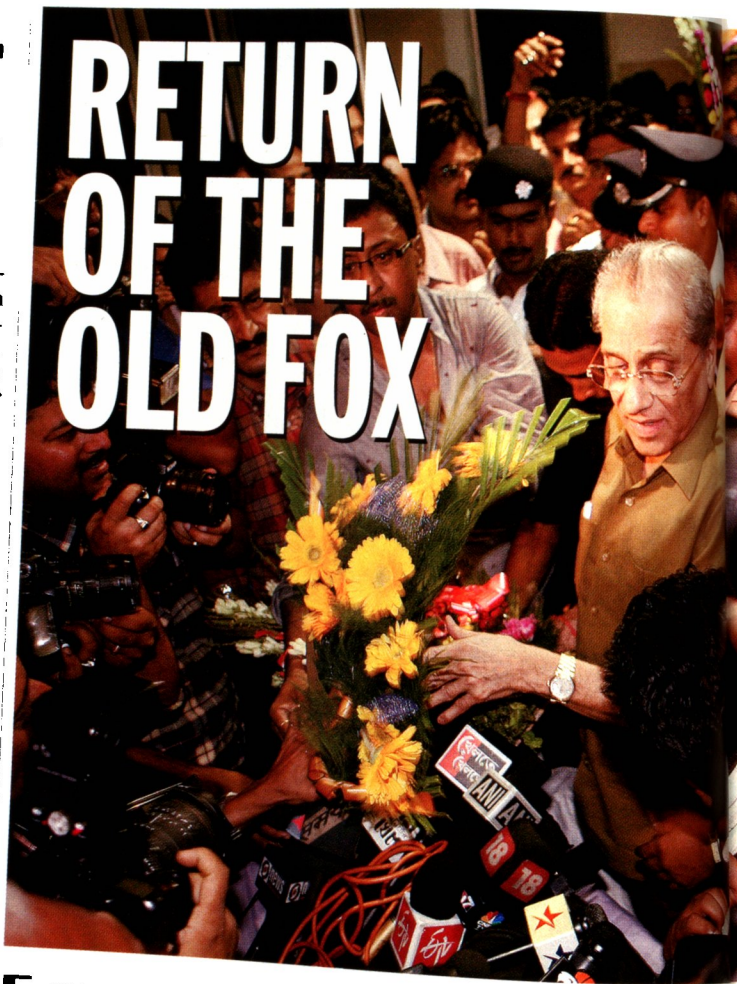
In a whirlpool of people and cameras, in a noisy storm of celebration and clamour, a wily veteran returned to his old stomping grounds. When Jagmohan Dalmiya, former BCCI president and long-standing chief of the Cricket Association of Bengal (CAB), re-entered the corridors from where he had wielded power over world cricket, it was possible to sense an immediate change in temperature.

On the face of it, Dalmiya won a one-sided state cricket election in a state peripheral to the ruling BCCI's power equation. Magnanimous and chatty, the man all Bengal cricket calls Jaggu Da, was at pains to make it clear that his focus was the here and the now, on Bengal cricket, the Maidan and its clubs. Yet, there is no telling where his distant gaze would be. Nobody with even the sketchiest understanding of cricket's prime powerbroker from the 1990s would bet against Dalmiya's resurgence on the national stage.

Banned and humiliated, Dalmiya had been virtually cast out by the current BCCI regime after his election defeat to Sharad Pawar in 2005. Slapped with showcause notices and court cases around misappropriation of funds to the tune of Rs 4 crore by the Pawar camp, Dalmiya had gone into an unusually silent retreat after he resigned as CAB president in December 2006. He left the field open for the then commissioner of police Prasun Mukherjee to take charge of the CAB. But Dalmiya's return to Eden Gardens now, many believe, may make him a force multiplied.

Before the election, Dalmiya had told a local newspaper, "Eden is my second home, I can come back any time." His margin of victory over Mukherjee—71 to 47—proved it. Dalmiya will relish this success more than his earlier triumphs at the helm of the sport. To rub more salt into the ruling group's wounds, his entire panel

RETURN OF THE OLD FOX



"I have not come back for the sake of power. This time I have come back to the CAB to improve Bengal cricket."

JAGMOHAN DALMIYA, FORMER BCCI PRESIDENT

of candidates for CAB posts won their respective polls and wiped out the presence of the Mukherjee group.

In a clear departure from the 2006 election, Mukherjee, who is no longer the commissioner of police, was not backed by the state government. That time too, he had lost to Dalmiya, but only by five votes. West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya was then extremely vocal in extending his support to Mukherjee, calling Dalmiya an "evil power". This time around, no such support was forthcoming for Mukherjee, who has appeared to have blotted his book through his handling of the Rizwanur Rahman case, which

caused a lot of embarrassment to the state government and the police. During Mukherjee's tenure, there were also allegations that the CAB had incurred losses to the tune of Rs 41 lakh during just one Test match.

Dalmiya was able to edge back to centrestage in the summer by becoming the rallying point for majority of CAB's affiliated units, which were demanding a larger piece of the IPL pie. The dissatisfaction with Mukherjee appeared to have set in then and Dalmiya was quick to spot and exploit it to his advantage.

Mukherjee said he felt betrayed in defeat. "My so-called supporters... did